

Def. Let $\beta: I \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^3$ be a unit-speed curve.

A vector field β' is called the unit tangent vector field on β , denote $T = \beta'$.

The derivative $T' = \beta''$ is called the curvature vector field of β .

The value $k(s) = \|T'(s)\|$ ($s \in I$) is called the curvature function of β .

To restriction s.t. $k > 0$,
the unit-vector field $N = \frac{T'}{k}$ is called the principal normal vector field of β .

The cross product $B = T \times N$ on β is called the binormal vector field of β .

Lemma. Let β be a unit-speed curve in $\mathbb{R}^3$ with $k > 0$,

Then, the three vector fields T, N , and B on β are unit vector fields that are mutually orthogonal at each point.

Proof. By definition, $\|T\| = \|\beta'\| = 1$. And since the curvature $k > 0$, $\|N\| = \frac{1}{k} \cdot \|T'\| = 1$.

And, since $\|T\|^2 = T \cdot T$ is constant, $2T \cdot T' = 0$, so $T \perp N$.

therefore the binormal, $\|B\| = \|T \times N\|^2 = \|T\|^2 \cdot \|N\|^2 - (T \cdot N)^2 = 1 - 0 = 1$.

In summary, $T = \beta'$, $N = T'/k$, $B = T \times N$, and $\{T, N, B\}$ is orthonormal.

Since $B \cdot T = 0$, $B' \cdot T + B \cdot T' = 0$ by differentiate. Therefore,

$$B' \cdot T = -B \cdot T' = -B \cdot kN = 0$$

And since B is unit, $B' \cdot B = 0$, thus, there is a scalar value function τ s.t.

$$B' = -\tau N$$

, called the torsion. Now

Thm. Let β be a unit-speed curve in $\mathbb{R}^3$ with curvature $k > 0$ and torsion τ ,

$$\begin{aligned} T' &= kN \\ N' &= -kT + \tau B \\ B' &= -\tau N \end{aligned} \quad \begin{bmatrix} 0 & k & 0 \\ -k & 0 & \tau \\ 0 & -\tau & 0 \end{bmatrix} \begin{bmatrix} T \\ N \\ B \end{bmatrix}$$

Proof. The first and third rows are just definition. To show the second, observe $N' = (N' \cdot T)T + (N' \cdot N)N + (N' \cdot B)B$

Now, $N' \cdot T = N \cdot T' = 0$ and $N' \cdot B = N \cdot B' = 0$ gives the results.

